

Ethics ETH2425-0364: Harriet Galvin

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Category	Staff
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Faculty	Erasmus School of Social and Behavioural Sciences
Current status	Approved after amendments made

Ethics application

Application for approval of amendments

Please describe the amendments you intend to make to your research protocol.

OVERVIEW OF AMENDMENTS:

Please refer to the uploaded file "20230912_safebet_POC_Amendment_Suppliment_UPDATED" for details on all amendment requests.

Amendment 1: Changes to Quantitative Data Collection Period

- Extended the original 6-month data collection period to 10 months.
- Introduced three phases: 1) POC Preparation Data Collection (1 month), 2) POC Data Collection (6 months), and 3) Extended Data Collection for BETA baseline evaluation period (3 months).

Amendment 2: Changes to the Participant Inclusion Threshold

- Increased the minimum Active Gambling Days (AGD) from 15 to 20 for participant eligibility.

Amendment 3: Changes in Participant Consent Procedures (UPDATED following initial review by Tijs Gelens)

- Streamlined consent procedures in consultation with EUR and operators' privacy officers.
- Moved away from explicit informed consent to an approach aligned with existing privacy policies.

Amendment 4: Changes to Sample Size and Recruitment Procedures

- Revised the initial sample size from 200,000 to ~8,000 per operator using a stratified sampling method.
- Introduced a rolling recruitment strategy to replenish the sample based on stratified risk categories.

Each of these amendments aims to address challenges in the project while aligning with ethical standards and practical constraints. They collectively serve to strengthen the study's methodology, ethical considerations, and overall feasibility.

OVERVIEW OF AMENDMENTS (12-2024):

Please refer to the uploaded file "202412_safebet_POC_Amedment" for detailed information on the proposed changes.

This amendment reflects necessary adjustments to the A Safe Bet Proof of Concept (POC) for the Netherlands site to comply with the new regulatory framework introduced by the KSA. The updated design transitions from a dynamic, tailored RG tool approach to an observational study utilizing standardized mandatory tools. The focus is now on collecting baseline data to inform future phases (Alpha and Beta) of the project.

Key updates include:

- Adapting the study framework to operate within the limitations of KSA regulations, maintaining only the tools and features mandated by law, including deposit, time, and withdrawal limits, alongside the scheduled breaks feature.
- Revising participant communications to ensure transparency about the observational nature of the study while maintaining participant engagement through occasional feedback check-ins.
- Shifting the study's focus to baseline data collection, observing player interactions with the standardized RG tools under real-world conditions to establish foundational insights.

These changes aim to preserve the integrity of the research, enhance participant protection, and ensure compliance with both ethical and regulatory requirements while maintaining the study's broader objectives.

Please upload any other files that are relevant for your application

Attached files

20222707_safebetPOC_QuanInformed consent_EN.pdf

22022707_safebetPOC_QuallInformedConsent_EN.pdf

20220510_safebetPOC_QualSemiStrucInterview_EN.pdf

20220610_safebetPOC_UserSatSurveys_EN.pdf

20221608_safebetPOC_Permission for Use of Existing Data.pdf

20230905_safebet_POC_QuanInformed consent_EN_AMENDMENT.pdf

20230912_safebet_POC_data flow.pdf

20230912_safebet_POC_Amendment_Supplimentary Information.pdf

20230912_safebet_POC_Amendment_Suppliment_UPDATED.pdf

2024012_safebet_POC_Amendment_SupplementaryInfo.pdf

20241201_safebet_POC_Amedment.pdf

Information Brief & Informed Consent – Quantitative study

*Since the gambling operators are mandated by national regulations to protect their customers by enacting a range of measures, including monitoring players' gambling activity, players cannot choose to **not** receive RG measures. However, a player status as a research participant is defined by players' choice of sharing their data for scientific research purposes (opt – out options in privacy settings). Players are free to withdraw from sharing their data at any time with no consequences and without depriving them of access to the POC RG tools. The project is carried out online on the operators' platform, who are responsible for players' data use and privacy conditions. Hence, there is no transfer of written documents between participant and the researchers. When the RG framework is deployed on the operator's site, the communication below is presented via a pop-up message at the next-player-login.*

Welcome back to [operator site],
new features have been added to your player interface and we have updated our Privacy Policy [hyperlink to PP page] to bring you a more personalised player environment. Some of your data will now be shared with our research partners to help tailor your gaming experience in support of smarter and safer gambling practices.
You can always review your data privacy setting by clicking below.

By continuing to play, you agree to these changes.
[icon – link to close pop-up and continue play] CONTINUE
[icon – link to privacy settings] REVIEW PRIVACY SETTINGS

Players can access their privacy settings at any time where information is provided on the terms of use and sharing of their data. By deselecting (ie, opt out) an icon embedded within the privacy settings of each operator site, players (i.e., participants) revoke consent for their data to be shared for scientific research purposes.

Here at [operator site] we're committed to helping you use our platform to its full potential and we want to make sure that everyone gets the most out of their playing experience. [Operator] has teamed up with an academic research team (Erasmus University Rotterdam and University of Amsterdam) to help us evaluate how best to support your responsible gambling choices. By agreeing to share your data you not only help us improve the safety of your gambling experience but also help provide safer practices to our whole community.

All internet users have a right to decide what is going to happen with their data. Preserving your privacy is our top priority; all your data when shared will be fully anonymised, removing all identifying particulars or details that are personal to you.

If you have any questions on our data sharing policy or would like more information regarding our research endeavours to support responsible play, please contact our customer service [hyperlink to operatory customer service].

NB: All information here will be translated to Dutch for use on Holland Casino's site.

Information Brief and Informed Consent - Qualitative study

A list of pre-selected userIDs will be communicated to the gambling operators, who will invite the corresponding players to an online form where they can express their interest in participating in the qualitative study and receive a registration link to the informed consent form and interview planning. Informed consent will ask asked to indicate their agreement with all the terms for participation, if they do not agree with one or more of the terms, they cannot take part in the qualitative interview. The below information will be presented to the participant via the link received from the gambling operator.

Welcome to the Safe Bet: Player Satisfaction and User Experience Investigation!

Thank you for playing on [operator site] and being a valued member of our player community. Here at [operator site] we're committed to helping you use our platform to its full potential so that everyone can get the most out of their playing experience.

We are very curious to know how you as a player interact with our site and your experiences with our player protection features. With your feedback we hope to improve and further develop our player experience. Perhaps you found certain elements work very well, or less well, and you see opportunities to improve the gambler's experience.

We have selected you from a large group of players, because we think you are in a unique position to provide us with valuable insights. To get the best information and ensure your voice is truly heard we are inviting you to a video call interview!

Please read the following information carefully, and if you would like to participate, please follow the link to our consent form and indicate a time that suits you best.

The key interview details:

- When: a time that suits you!
- Where: online – Zoom or MS Teams – call lasting approx. 30 mins.
- Who: [Operator] has teamed up with a research group from the Erasmus University Rotterdam and University of Amsterdam, who will conduct the interviews
- What ('s in it for me): you will receive a [Amazon.uk or Bol.com] voucher worth [10£ or 10€] for participating in the interview.

NB: Participation in this interview is completely voluntary and confidential. Voluntary, because you are free to stop participating in the interview at any time without giving any reason (even after completion of the interview). Confidential, as all interview data is stored, processed, and reported anonymously and securely. It is important to note that audio recordings will be made of the interviews. These recordings will be transcribed with all your personal information, such as names and locations, removed to protect your privacy. The interviews will then be anonymously analysed together, and the original audio recordings will be destroyed.

We would greatly appreciate your time and input. Please use the button below to let us know you want to help:

[button "yes, I would like to give my feedback and participate in an interview" (next page – consent form)].

If, for any reason, you would rather not take part, you can let us know using the button below. We will assume that you prefer not to participate in this interview if we do not receive a response within 14 days. We will not contact you again in this case. There is no need for you to take any action. We would like to thank you for your time and attention and will not contact you again.

[button "No, I would rather not take part in the interview" (next page – online form closure)].

Consent form

[if they clicked on the "yes" button in the briefing message].

As the interview is conducted over the video call, there is no transfer of documents to the participants. When clicking on the " yes, I would like to give my feedback and participate in an interview " button in the briefing message, participants enter next page screen with the following information. On this page, participants must indicate separately whether they agree with all the conditions. If they do not agree with one or more of the conditions, they cannot take part in the interview.

How nice of you to help us and help improve [operator site] for everyone! Your valuable feedback is much appreciated and will help improving yours and other players' experience and protection.

First of all, we would like to draw your attention to the following.

In order to use your feedback it is necessary that you give us permission to do so. Please note! If you do not tick one or more of the statements below, you will not be able to participate in the interview.

- ☐ I confirm that I have read and understand the information about the interview in the information page.
- ☐ I know that my participation is completely voluntary and that I can withdraw my consent at any time without having to give a reason.
- ☐ I understand that interview data may be used for scientific research purposes. I consent to this, assuming my anonymity is guaranteed.
- ☐ I give permission for audio recordings to be made, assuming they will be deleted after they have been anonymised into (digital) written text
- ☐ I understand that I can, now or in the future, address questions to the customer services team of [operator site] at [operator customer service email].
- ☐ I understand that for any complaints about this study I can contact the customer services team of [operator site] at [operator customer service email].

To ensure the naturalistic design of the study is upheld and that we comply with the operators' terms of service and privacy regulation (under GDPR) all direct contact with participants will be conducted via the gambling operator.

Please click "Next" to submit your responses and be taken to video call time-slots!

Participants will then be directed to the interview planning schedule (Doodle.com) and indicate preferred times for the interview to be conducted.

NB: All information here will be translated to Dutch for use on Holland Casino's site.

Semi Structured Interviews - Qualitative study

The interviews will be conducted by the PhD candidate with the support of one Dutch native-speaker student assistant and will take approximately 30 minutes to complete.

Responsible Gambling (RG); Responsible Gambling Tool (RGT)

Interviews will follow a semi-structured script on the following topics: type of RGT Modality, RGT preferences, RGT quality and RGT delivery.

Theme	Sub-Theme	Probing question example:	Sub-question example:
RGT Modality	Received RGTs	<i>"Have you seen any messages or other functions on the website concerning safe gambling practices (e.g., information about problems, setting limits) from [operator site]?"</i>	<i>"What is your day to day experience with safe gambling practices on [operator site]?"</i>
	RGT interactions	<i>"How would you describe your level of interaction with safe gambling practices on [operator site]?"</i>	<i>"Can you describe how you make use of any tools on [operator site] for your safe gambling during an average gambling session or period?"</i>
			<i>"What tools or other elements could be added to communicate safe gambling practices through [operator site]?"</i>
RGT Preferences	Most preferred	<i>"What do you like most about the tools to support safe gambling practices offered by [operator site]?"</i>	<i>"What is the main benefit you feel you receive from the tools offered by [operator site] to support safe gambling practices?"</i>
			<i>"What tools are most important to you in supporting your play experience?"</i>
	Least preferred	<i>"What do you like least about the tools to support safe gambling practices offered by [operator site]?"</i>	<i>"What annoys you about the tools you received – any in particular?"</i>
RGT Quality	Utility	<i>"What do you consider to be useful or interesting about the safe gambling (or RG) resources (and tools) offered by [operator site]?"</i>	<i>"In what ways did the RG tools help you or support your play experience?"</i>

			<i>"How useful do you think the safe gambling tools offered by [operator site] are at supporting your play experience?"</i>
			<i>"What tools could be added to support your play experience?"</i>
			<i>"How likely are you to continue making use of the safe gambling tools offered by [operator site]?"</i>
	Appropriateness	<i>"Did you think the content of the safe gambling messaging was appropriate?"</i>	<i>"How appropriate do you think the language used by [operator site] concerning safe gambling was?"</i>
			<i>"What messages would you design to encourage people to engage with safe gambling practices?"</i>
	Relevance	<i>"How relevant were tools to support safe gambling tools offered by [operator site] to supporting your play experience?"</i>	<i>"Are there any changes you would make so tools for safe gambling practices are more relevant to you?"</i>
	Clarity	<i>"How clear and understandable did you find the safe gambling tools offered by [operator site]?"</i>	<i>"What could improve the safe gambling content clarity offered [operator site]?"</i>
RGT Delivery	Accessibility	<i>"How accessible did you find the safe gambling tools offered by [operator site]?"</i>	<i>"Were the RGTs accessible to you when you wanted them to be?"</i>
			<i>"Were the RGTs accessible to you where you wanted them to be?"</i>
			<i>"What tools or web features could be added to organize the safe gambling content of [operator site] better?"</i>
	Interference	<i>"Were there occasions where you experienced friction or annoyance from the safe gambling tools offered by [operator site]?"</i>	<i>"Were there any occasions when you felt the safe gambling tools detracted from your play experience?"</i>
			<i>"Were safe gambling messages delivered at appropriate times?"</i>
	Taxation	<i>"How did you feel about the amount of safe gambling content / messages /tools you received in comparison to before the user interface was updated by [operator site]?"</i>	<i>"What would make you more likely to follow through on a safe gambling action suggested by the website?"</i>

User Satisfaction Intercept Surveys – Quantitative Study

User satisfaction with Responsible Gambling Tools (RGTs) will be assessed via short intercept user satisfaction surveys released live on the operator's website during the quantitative study period. These brief surveys will assess a given RGT deployed to the player based on the following dimensions when applicable: satisfaction, intrusiveness, usability, and utility perception.

They will include max 1 question per dimension rated on a five-point Likert scale [1-5; strongly agree to strongly disagree], with an additional response option indicating non-use or viewing the given RGT [single item selection tick box]. Surveys will be distributed over the study period after implementing a RGT using a quasi-random deployment approach. Questions will be specific to the RGT received by the player and aligned to the function of the RGT (i.e., call-to-action, educational content to raise awareness or personalised feedback). Examples are as follows:

Call-to-action RGT (e.g., prompt for a gambler to set a new/change their deposit limit.)
<i>The deposit limit prompt interrupted my gambling session. [Intrusiveness]</i>
<i>The deposit limit prompt made it easy for me to change my limit. [Usability]</i>
<i>The deposit limit prompt was useful in setting a new limit. [Utility]</i>
<i>I did not see or use the deposit limit prompt.</i>
Educational content RGT (e.g., notification with financial advice on how and the benefit of setting an appropriate deposit limit.)
<i>I was satisfied with the deposit limit advice I received. [Satisfaction]</i>
<i>The deposit limit advice helped me set an appropriate limit. [Utility]</i>
<i>I did not see the deposit limit notification.</i>
Personalised feedback RGT (e.g., notification with personalised feedback on their depositing activity in the prior X-period.)
<i>The deposit activity notification gave me valuable insights into my own deposit activity. [Utility]</i>
<i>The deposit activity notification interrupted my gambling session. [Intrusiveness]</i>
<i>I did not see the deposit activity notification.</i>

Permission for Use of Existing Data

We will obtain primary data directly from individuals. We do **not** obtain publicly available data or obtain existing data. However, the data is collected by a collaborative effort between the Erasmus University Rotterdam and two industry partners; Playtech and Holland Casino.

A Collaboration Agreement between all parties has been made (under the supervision and advice of EUR legal counsel Renée Hanegraaf) along with a Data Sharing Agreement between all parties (under the supervision and advice of EUR privacy officer Bo Schijven).

Amendment 'A Safe Bet' Ethics Application

Information Brief & Informed Consent – Quantitative study

*Gambling operators are mandated by national regulations to enact various responsible gambling (RG) measures aimed at protecting their customers, which includes monitoring players' gambling activity. Due to this regulatory requirement, players do not have the option **not to** receive these RG measures. The data collected to evaluate these RG measures will be used for scientific research to enhance responsible gambling tools and practices. This project operates entirely online on the operators' platform, which is responsible for players' data use and privacy conditions. As such, there is no written document transfer between participants and researchers. Players should be notified and informed about the use of their data and that they have the right to object (on grounds relating to their particular situation) to the gambling operators collecting and sharing data with third parties; however, they cannot in a broader sense object to the data being used for this research project. When the RG framework is deployed, the information about the project and data use will be provided to players through a pop-up message upon their next login to the operators' site, as shown below.*

POP-UP NOTIFICATION

Welcome back to [Operator Site],

We've introduced new features to your player interface to make your experience more tailored and supportive of smarter and safer gambling practices. Here at [Operator Site], our commitment is to help you make informed choices while enjoying our platform.

We're working in collaboration with research experts from Erasmus University Rotterdam and the University of Amsterdam to evaluate and enhance responsible gambling features on our platform. This is part of our ongoing commitment to improving safety measures and ensuring responsible gambling tools are as effective and user-friendly as possible. This collaborative effort aims to positively impact the experience of all users, supporting a safer and more enjoyable community for everyone.

What Your Continued Play Means

By choosing to play on this site, you're already participating under our existing privacy terms and conditions. This means that some of your gameplay data will be shared with the research team to help improve responsible gambling tools. Rest assured, we have carefully selected the data which we share with the research team. The research team will not know who you are and that you use our services.

For more details on our data-sharing policy and ongoing research to promote responsible play, you're welcome to check out our [Privacy Policy]([hyperlink to PP page](#)). If you have more questions, our [customer service]([hyperlink to operator customer service](#)) is always here to assist you.

[Icon: "I Understand"]

EXAMPLE CONTENT FOR RG HOMEPAGE

Online gambling is growing fast, and it's super important that it's done in a safe and responsible way. Right now, many tools meant to help with this aren't based on solid science and usually only focus on players already at high risk. That's why we're supporting the effort of [operator site].

The 'A Safe Bet' project is a collaboration between academic experts from Erasmus University Rotterdam & the University of Amsterdam and [Operator Site]. The goal? To enhance the safety and enjoyment of online gambling. Existing tools, while helpful, could be much more effective. We are aiming to fine-tune these tools based on comprehensive research and data. The project will run over two years, during which we'll test and optimise a range of innovative features.

The initial phase focuses on understanding the feasibility and impact of new tools designed to encourage responsible play. Based on player experiences, we'll refine these tools to suit individual needs and risk levels better. Our ultimate aim is to deploy this new framework across our online platforms in the Netherlands and the UK, enriching the gambling environment with more effective and personalised safety measures.

Questions? Curiosities? Feel free to reach out to [Operator Site's] customer service, who can direct any inquiries to our team.

Thank you for your interest in this initiative aimed at making online gambling as safe and enjoyable as possible.

GDPR	UK GDPR Data protection Act 2018
Definitions	Does the GDPR still apply? Yes. The GDPR is retained in domestic law as the UK GDPR, but the UK has the independence to keep the framework under review. The UK GDPR sits alongside an amended version of the DPA 2018. The key principles, rights and obligations remain the same.
Controller: the natural or legal person which determines the purposes and means of the processing of personal data	
Processor: a natural or legal person which processes personal data on behalf of the controller	
Scientific research	Scientific research
- Recital 50 - Art. 5(1)(b) GDPR - Art. 89 GDPR	- Recital 50 GDPR - Art. 5(1)(b) GDPR - Art. 89 GDPR - Art. 19 Data Protection Act 2018

Data collection by HC & PlayTech (legal obligations)

HC and PlayTech need, and thus already collect, data to comply with their legal obligations. The data collected includes the data that is required for the EUR to conduct the research project. As HC and PlayTech require the data to comply with legal obligations, the collection of the data is mandatory, therefore HC and PlayTech cannot base the processing on consent.

PlayTech still needs to properly inform the players for which purpose it needs to collect which data (general privacy statement and pop-up message). PlayTech also needs to do this in case the introduction of a new interface comes with more/new data collection. The information provided, if not already covered, should also include that the further processing could be done by a third party (conducting scientific research).

But over all, by registering on the operator website and agreeing to operators privacy policy and terms of use, players consent to participate in evaluation and monitoring of responsible gambling measures.

Sharing the data with EUR

- Further use (privacy)
 - Further sharing of the data (HC and PlayTech to EUR)
 - Further use for scientific research purposes is specifically mentioned and should be considered to be compatible lawful processing operations (see 5(1)(b) and recital 50 GDPR)
 - Data is extensively anonymised, inline with Art. 89(1) GDPR
- Anonymous data (for EUR); in line with the Breyer case (GDPR does not apply)

If data is however not anonymous for EUR, then the EUR processes the data in accordance with the following:

- Passive consent (ethics) and Public interest (privacy)
 - Data is collected by HC and PlayTech and shared with/used by the EUR, after data is extensively anonymised
 - Players are properly informed by HC and PlayTech (and have the opportunity to object, on grounds relating to their particular situation).
 - The EUR does not receive information necessary to be able to inform the players (data minimisation)

GDPR compliance check:

- Principles**
 - Purpose; clearly defined
 - Data minimisation; applied
 - Transparency; applied
- Art 6 GDPR (PlayTech):** Legal obligation
- Art 6 GDPR (EUR):** Anonymous data or public interest
- Art 9 GDPR (EUR):** not applicable
- Roles of each party:** Both parties determine their own purpose and means
 - HC and PlayTech: wants to have its methods assessed (by an independent party)
 - EUR: Conducting scientific research; needs to uphold scientific integrity (honesty, diligence, transparency, independence and responsibility)

Informing data subjects Art. 13 GDPR (for HC & PlayTech)
Provide the data subject with information (e.g., purpose of processing, recipients of data)

Data subject rights (for HC & PlayTech)

- Processing is not based on consent; so no withdrawal
- Art. 15 (give information)
- Art. 17 (erase information if data are no longer relevant or objection is granted)
- Art. 21 (right to object)

Holland Casino (Responsible gambling)
[Privacy statement Holland Casino](#)

Holland Casino is required by law to collect data

- on how players engage with gambling and any potential risk factors for addiction that can be inferred from it
- for establish a "monitoring database."

Legal basis: Legal obligation (Art. 6(1)(c) GDPR)

Additionally, Holland Casino states that they may collect and/or anonymize the players personal data for scientific research.

PlayTech (Responsible gambling)

[Privacy statement Sun Bingo](#)

PlayTech needs to comply with gambling regulations. In order to do so, it collects additional information from persons using their services.

Related purposes:

- To use data for research analysis, behavioral monitoring and testing with the outcome to understand potential harm to players. To help encourage safe play and target interventions where necessary.
- To monitor gambling patterns and to identify possible responsible gambling concerns.
- To prevent you from using our Website and Services if you have requested that we do so
- To comply with any deposit, spend or loss limits that you have set

Legal basis: Legal obligation (Art. 6(1)(c) GDPR)

"Our license also requires that we make sure you gamble responsibly. This means that we will monitor your gambling activities to check that you are gambling within your means. If we have any concerns about your gambling, then we are required to contact you to make sure everything is okay. We take social responsibility very seriously."

"As such, we may collect information about your physical or mental health. To help ensure that our customers gamble responsibly, it's important we understand why they self-exclude (or when they should be contacted about the possibility of self-excluding). We therefore only use this type of data to ensure that you are gambling responsibly, to contact you if we are concerned that you are not gambling responsibly, to enforce any self-exclusion request, and to help us to better identify any responsible gambling concerns in the future for our customers."

Anonymous or pseudonymous data

If the party receiving the data set does not possess any means reasonably likely to identify natural person, the data is anonymous for that party. Even if this data contains unique data items.

Matching of rows to players

- The information received will have unique rows (singling out is possible)
- For the interview stage of the project, rows will be selected by EUR and shared with HC and PlayTech. HC and PlayTech will match the rows to players and invite the selected players to participate in the interview study.

Data EUR receives

- Even when data is matched, HC and PlayTech will not share identifying information.
- If a player wishes to participate in the interview study, the player can sign up voluntarily and directly share personal data with EUR
- And only if required and after a player has been fully informed and consented to participating in the interview study, might a row be linked to a person and might such information be shared with EUR.

See [Browse articles](#) (EU case law, not directly relevant for the UK)

EUR (conducting scientific research)

For EUR conducting scientific research is a legal responsibility. A task assigned by law.

- [Wat op het hoger onderwijs en wetenschappelijk onderzoek](#)
- Article 1.3 Whw

Legal basis: Anonymous data or Public Interest (Art. 6(1)(e) GDPR)

EUR determines the research to be conducted

- Sets the hypothesis
- Specifies which information is required
- Which methods will be applied
- Which result will be published
- Which information needs to be archived and for how long
- Has to uphold [scientific integrity](#)

Informing data subjects Art. 14 GDPR (for EUR)
As EUR does not receive any information through which EUR can identify and reach the data subjects, informing the data subjects is impossible (Art. 14(5)(b) GDPR)

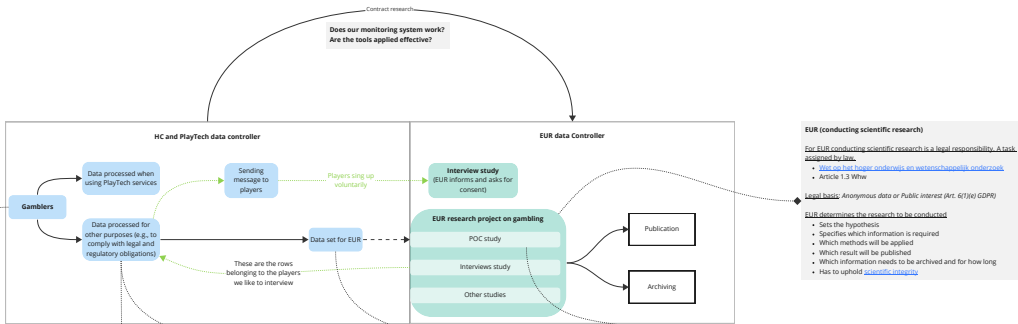
Identification and data subject rights Art. 11 GDPR
There is no obligation to process additional information to identify the data subject solely to comply with the GDPR.

If a controller cannot identify a data subject, Articles 15-20 GDPR do not apply (most of the data subject rights).

Right to object (Art. 21 GDPR)
Participants still have the right to object. They can do so with HC or PlayTech. Such a request will be assessed on case-by-case basis.

Identification by HC & PlayTech
Whilst EUR does not have the means to identify the participants, HC and PlayTech do. Hence, with required additional information from PlayTech, the participants information might/can be removed.

As EUR is a controller, it would be up to the EUR to assess whether data is to be removed in accordance with ethical obligations and the GDPR.



Amendment 'A Safe Bet' Ethics Application

As per our comment, please see the requested amendments to the "A Safe Bet" project.

Amendment 1: Changes to Quantitative Data Collection Period

Under the original application, we stated that the quantitative part of the study would last a period of 6 months. However, 6 months only accounts for the active data collection period with the live POC RG framework. As such, we provided an amended overview to encompass the phased timeline.

1. **POC Preparation Data Collection:** One month prior to the launch of the POC RG framework live on the gambling interface, we will begin to collect player behavioral tracking data. This is required to accurately assess and provide the initial risk-level assignment for RG tool recommendations at the start of the study period (i.e., average of the previous 30 calendar days). This month extends the study period by one month before the POC commences (i.e., October 1st to start on November 1st).
2. **POC Data Collection Period (unchanged):** On November 1st POC RG framework will go live and run for a period of 6 months as previously specified.
3. **Extended Data Collection for BETA Baseline Evaluation:** As mentioned in the original application, the POC dataset will further serve as the baseline period required for the full-scale impact evaluation of the BETA version of the RG framework. To achieve a good quality dataset, after the conclusion of the POC study period, the RG framework will remain active for an additional 3 months on the participants' accounts. The data from these three months will be combined with the POC dataset to serve as the 9-month baseline period for the BETA evaluation.
4. **Total Duration:** The data collection period is 10 months; 1 month for baseline data collection for the first POC risk assignment, 6 months for the POC, and an additional 3 months for extended data collection aimed at preparing for the BETA phase.

NB. This amendment aligns with our initial application, where it was indicated that the POC is Phase 1 and a subsequent Phase 2 will follow. We are now in the process of preparing the ethics application for the BETA phase. However, we felt that an amendment of the current application was necessary for ethical considerations and to provide a foundational structure for the upcoming BETA impact evaluation.

Amendment 2: Changes to the Participant Inclusion Threshold

In our initial ethics application, we stated that participants must have at least 15 active gambling days (AGD) in the prior period for accurate risk assessment. Due to operational constraints, this has been **updated to a minimum of 20 AGD**. This adjustment not only aligns with the technical constraints of the risk assessment algorithm but also strengthens the safety measures, ensuring a more reliable risk-level assignment for participants.

Amendment 3: Changes in Participant Consent Procedures

After consultation with the privacy officers of the collaborating gambling operators in both the United Kingdom and the Netherlands and in coordination with the ESSB Privacy Officer, we ask to amend our participant consent procedures only for the quantitative part of the study.

Rationale for Amendment:

1. **Operator Privacy Policies (informing players):** EUR is not collecting the data from the players, the operators do. Hence, both the UK and NL operators' privacy statement explains clearly that the operators need to collect data to comply with their legal obligations (UK and Dutch online gambling regulations). Additionally, the privacy statements include provisions for sharing anonymised and/or personal data with third parties for research and development purposes. As a result, players have been informed about the data collection and sharing thereof and agreed to these conditions by signing up to and using the operator's services. Further information will be provided to the players with the release of the new user interface including the POC RG framework (introduced by both operators).
2. **Receiving anonymous data:** All data transferred to the EUR is extensively anonymised (for the EUR) by the operators. The operators will not share details through which the EUR can identify the individual players. This adheres to privacy regulations and safeguards participant confidentiality.
3. **Data Privacy Officer Collaboration:** The data collection and transfer procedures, including this amendment, have been drafted in collaboration with the ESSB Privacy Officer, ensuring full compliance with relevant privacy laws.

Impact of Changes:

1. **Informed Consent:** Given that players have already been informed and agreed to collection and sharing of their data for research purposes via the operators' privacy statements and that all transferred data will be extensively anonymised, we have determined that obtaining explicit informed consent (i.e., the previous "opt-out" option) is not necessary for the quantitative part of this research. By registering on the operator's website and agreeing to operator's privacy policy and terms of use, players already consent to participate in the evaluation and monitoring of responsible gambling measures and to share their data to third parties.
2. **Notification Changes:** The operators will still notify the players about the release of the new interface, their updated responsible gambling policy, and the data sharing. The notification will be in the form of a pop-up message, which all players will see upon their next login to the operators' site. They will not have an option to opt out of this specific research initiative.
3. **Removal of Exit:** The pop-up notification will not include an "exit" icon but will include an "OKAY" button asking for players confirmation that they have read and understood the notification message. This ensures that players acknowledge the information to continue using the platform and the use of their data for scientific purposes, in line with the operators' existing terms and privacy policies.
4. **Data Privacy:** The responsibility for data use and privacy conditions continues to lie with the operators up until the sharing of the data (operators are effectively data controllers). Once data is shared with EUR, the EUR is responsible for data use and privacy conditions (EUR becomes data controller only upon receiving the data).

5. **Transparency and Accessibility of Information:** Besides the pop-up notification, information on the research aims will be available to players anytime through the dedicated, responsible gambling homepage on both UK and NL sites.

NB. In support of the amendments to participant consent procedures, we have uploaded two documents: 1) An updated version of the pop-up notification when gamblers receive the POC user interface; and 2) a data flow document crafted by (Bo Schijven), ESSB Privacy Officer, providing a comprehensive and visual representation of the data flow specific to the POC phase of the study.

Amendment 4: Changes to Sample Size and Recruitment Procedures

Our initial ethics application stipulated a desired sample size of 200,000 players, assuming a full-scale launch across both operators. In a scenario where this wasn't feasible, a random sample of 30,000 players was intended as an alternative.

Due to constraints and further insights into the operator customer base, we've revised the sampling strategy for the POC phase. In the initial phase of the POC we're employing a stratified sampling method that includes about ~8,000 players per operator for a total of ~24,000. These players are sampled within each operator customer base based on risk-level proportions: high-risk, 10% of the individual operator sample (approximately 800 players); moderate-risk, constituting 35% (around 2,800 players); and low-risk, making up the remaining and largest proportion at 55% (about 4,400 players). All gamblers in this initial sample must meet the criterion of 20 Active Gambling Days (20AGD) on the first day of POC data collection. The goal is to ensure this sample is representative of the larger player base, which includes 100,000-120,000 gamblers per operator. We have intentionally oversampled high-risk and medium-risk players to gather more data from these important segments. This stratified approach aims to create a balanced and representative initial dataset for evaluating RG framework across different risk profiles.

In addition to our initial stratified sample, we're amending the initial sampling method to include a rolling recruitment strategy as the POC progresses to account for player attrition during the 9 months of data collection, which can affect data quality for both the POC and Beta evaluations. As players "drop out"—defined as those accumulating fewer than 20 Active Gambling Days within a 90-day evaluation period—we will replenish the sample at the 90- and 180-day marks using the same stratified risk categories and 20 AGD inclusion criterion: 10% high-risk, 35% medium-risk, and 55% low-risk. Both the initial sample and the newly recruited players will be tagged at entry for identification and future analysis. Gamblers defined as "drop-outs" are not excluded from the POC study but are tagged as such. Their re-engagement with the gambling platform will be monitored, and their data will be retained if they meet the study criteria at a later stage. Additionally, new participants entering the POC study receive the same pop-up notification informing them of the user interface release and how their data will be used.

Amendment 'A Safe Bet' Ethics Application

OVERVIEW OF AMMENDEMENT:

Amendment 1: Changes to Quantitative Data Collection Period

- Extended the original 6-month data collection period to 10 months.
- Introduced three phases: 1) POC Preparation Data Collection (1 month), 2) POC Data Collection (6 months), and 3) Extended Data Collection for BETA Preparation (3 months).

Amendment 2: Changes to the Participant Inclusion Threshold

- Increased the minimum Active Gambling Days (AGD) from 15 to 20 for participant eligibility.

Amendment 3: **Changes in Participant Consent Procedures (UPDATED: following comments by Tijs Gelens)**

- Streamlined consent procedures in collaboration with privacy officers.
- Moved away from explicit informed consent to an approach aligned with operators' existing privacy policies.

Amendment 4: Changes to Sample Size and Recruitment Procedures

- Revised the initial sample size from 200,000 to ~8,000 per operator using a stratified sampling method.
- Introduced a rolling recruitment strategy to replenish the sample based on stratified risk categories.

Each of these amendments aims to address challenges in the project while aligning with ethical standards and practical constraints. They collectively serve to strengthen the study's methodology, ethical considerations, and overall feasibility.

AMMENDMENTS

1. Changes to Quantitative Data Collection Period

Under the original application, we stated that the quantitative arm of the study would last a period of 6 months. However, 6 months only accounts for the active data collection period with the live POC RG framework. As such, we provided an amended overview to encompass the phased timeline.

1. **POC Preparation Data Collection:** One month prior to the launch of the POC RG framework live on the gambling interface, we will collect begin to collect player behavioral tracking data. This is required to accurately assess and provide risk-level assignments for tailored RG tool recommendations at the study period onset. This month is for baseline data collection only and extends the study period by one month before the POC commences.
2. **POC Data Collection Period:** Immediately following the baseline data collection, the RG framework will go live and run for a period of 6 months as previously specified. During this time, we will collect data under the same aims; focusing on feasibility, user acceptance, and the potential impact of the RG framework.
3. **Extended Data Collection for BETA Preparation:** After the conclusion of the POC study period, the RG framework will remain active for an additional 3 months on

gambler accounts. Though the data from these three months won't be utilised under the current application, when combined with the POC data set it will serve as a 9-month baseline period required for the full-scale BETA impact evaluation.

4. **Total Duration:** The data collection period is 10 months; 1 month for preparation data collection for the POC risk assignment, with the RG framework active for a total duration of 9 months: 6 months for the POC, and an additional 3 months for extended data collection aimed at preparing for the BETA phase.

NB. This amendment aligns with our initial application, where it was indicated that this was Phase 1 and a subsequent Phase 2 was to follow. We are now in the process of preparing the ethics application for the BETA phase. However, we felt that an amendment of the current application was necessary for ethical considerations and to provide a foundational structure for the upcoming BETA impact evaluation.

2. Changes to the Participant Inclusion Threshold

In our initial ethics application, we stated that participants must have at least 15 active gambling days (AGD) in the prior period for accurate risk assessment. Due to operational constraints and compliance requirements, this has been **updated to a minimum of 20 AGD**. This adjustment not only aligns with the technical constraints of the risk assessment algorithm but also strengthens the safety measures, ensuring a more reliable and compliant risk-level assignment for participants. This change ensures both our research and the operators adhere to the highest standards of safety and compliance.

3. Changes in Participant Consent Procedures (See below for clarifications)

After consultation with the privacy officers of the collaborating gambling operators in both the United Kingdom and the Netherlands and in coordination with the EUR Data Privacy Officer, we ask to amend our participant consent procedures for the quantitative arm of the study.

Rationale for Amendment:

1. **Operator Privacy Policies (informing players):** EUR is not collecting the data from the players, the operators do. Hence, both the UK and NL operators' privacy statement explains clearly that the operators need to collect data to comply with their legal obligations (UK and Dutch online gambling regulations). Additionally, the privacy statements include provisions for sharing anonymised and/or personal data with third parties for research and development purposes. As a result, players have been informed about the data collection and sharing thereof and agreed to these conditions by signing up to and using the operator's services. Further information will be provided to the players with the release of the new interface (introduced by both operators).
2. **Receiving anonymous data:** All data transferred to the EUR is extensively anonymised (for the EUR) by the operators. The operators will not share details through which the EUR can identify the individual players. This adheres to privacy regulations and safeguards participant confidentiality.
3. **Data Privacy Officer Collaboration:** The data collection and transfer procedures, including this amendment, have been drafted in collaboration with the EUR Data Privacy Officer, ensuring full compliance with relevant privacy laws.

Impact of Changes:

1. **Informed Consent:** Given that players have already been informed and agreed to collection and sharing of their data via the operators' privacy statements and that all transferred data will be extensively anonymised, we have determined that obtaining explicit informed consent (i.e., the previous "opt-out" option) is not necessary for the quantitative arm of this research. By registering on the operator's website and agreeing to operator's privacy policy and terms of use, players already consent to participate in the evaluation and monitoring of responsible gambling measures.
2. **Notification Changes:** The operators will notify the players about the release of the new interface, their updated responsible gambling policy, and the data sharing. The notification will be in the form of a pop-up message, which all players will see upon their next login to the operators' site. They will not have an option to opt out of this specific research initiative.
3. **Removal of Exit:** The pop-up notification will not include an "exit" icon but will include an "OKAY" button asking for players confirmation that they have read and understood the notification message. This ensures that players acknowledge the information to continue using the platform, in line with the operators' existing terms and privacy policies.
4. **Data Privacy:** The responsibility for data use and privacy conditions continues to lie with the operators up until the sharing of the data. Once data is shared with EUR, the EUR is responsible for data use and privacy conditions.
5. **Transparency and Accessibility of Information:** Besides the pop-up notification, information on the research aims will be available to players anytime through the dedicated, responsible gambling homepage on both UK and NL sites.

NB. In support of the amendments to participant consent procedures, we have uploaded two documents: 1) An updated version of the player notification when gamblers receive the POC RG interface; and 2) a data flow document crafted by (Bo Schijven), EUR Data Privacy Officer, providing a comprehensive and visual representation of the data flow specific to the POC phase of the study.

Clarifications Following Review of Tijs Gelens:

- **Existing Data Collection by Operators:** It's important to emphasise that the data we are utilising will be collected by the gambling operators regardless of the researchers involvement. We are not involved in the primary data collection process. Instead, we are working with secondary data, which means that we do not directly interact or intervene with the participants.
- **Prior Consent Given by Gamblers:** Upon registration to the gambling platforms, gamblers have provided their explicit consent to be part of scientific research as part and have consented for the operators to share their data with third parties, including research institutions for scientific research purposes. This includes consenting to the monitoring and evaluation of RG tools, a cornerstone of our study. The general terms and conditions of both operators have been reviewed by the EUR privacy officer to verify these consent measures are taken and maintained by the gambling operators. We effectively become data controllers only when these anonymized datasets are shared with us by the operators.

- **Mandatory Obligations & The KOA Law:** The KOA law regulates online gambling activities, including the mandatory obligation of operators to evaluate and research responsible gambling and addiction prevention measures. Any individual wishing to gamble on such a platform must provide consent to these activities, as stipulated by the law. This is an imperative point because their consent is provided upstream, and this law supersedes the Dutch scientific and ethics code of conduct. Given the prevailing legal framework, we cannot and should not seek an additional layer of consent, as this would countermand the existing legal structure.
- **Notification and Transparency:** Players who are part of the POC study (i.e., included within the data collection pool) are informed about the specifics, objectives, and implications of the study. With the release of a POC new interface, all participants will receive explicit and transparent information about the research's scope and what it involves.
- **Protection of Participant Data:** All data that is shared with EUR is anonymized by the operators before transfer. We, as researchers, do not have the capability or means to identify individual participants from the data we receive. This ensures that the participants' privacy is upheld and there is a clear demarcation between the operator's data and what is shared with us.

4. Changes to Sample Size and Recruitment Procedures

Our initial ethics application stipulated a desired sample size of 200,000 players, assuming a full-scale launch across both operators. In a scenario where this wasn't feasible, a random sample of 30,000 players was intended as an alternative.

Due to constraints and further insights into the operator customer base, we've revised the sampling strategy for the POC phase. In the initial phase of the POC we're employing a stratified sampling method that includes about ~8,000 players per operator. These players are sampled based on risk-level proportions: high-risk, 10% of the sample (approximately 800 players); moderate-risk, constituting 35% (around 2,800 players); and low-risk, making up the remaining and largest proportion at 55% (about 4,400 players). All gamblers in this initial sample must meet the criterion of 20 Active Gambling Days (20AGD) on the first day of POC data collection. The goal is to ensure this sample is representative of the larger player base, which includes 100,000-120,000 gamblers per operator. We have intentionally oversampled high-risk and medium-risk players to gather more data from these important segments. This stratified approach aims to create a balanced and representative initial dataset for evaluating RG framework across different risk profiles.

In addition to our initial stratified sample, we're amending the initial sampling method to include a rolling recruitment strategy as the POC progresses. As players “drop out”—defined as those accumulating fewer than 20 Active Gambling Days within a 90-day evaluation period—we will replenish the sample using the same stratified risk categories: 10% high-risk, 35% medium-risk, and 55% low-risk. Both the initial sample and the newly recruited players will be tagged at entry for identification and future analysis. Gamblers defined as “drop-outs” are not excluded from the POC study but are tagged as such. Their re-engagement with the gambling platform will be monitored, and their data will be retained if they meet the study criteria at a later stage. Additionally, we note that new participants entering the

study receive the same notifications and are fully informed of the study objectives, their rights, and how their data will be used.

Rational for Rolling Recruitment

Our rolling recruitment strategy serves several essential functions for the integrity and success of our study. First, one of the critical requirements for the long-term success of this project is the accumulation of a sufficiently large and diverse dataset needed for the development of our machine-learning-based recommendation system, a crucial feature of the BETA phase. A fixed-sample approach, while providing valuable initial insights, is not adequate for this extended data requirement due to the natural attrition and fluctuation in player behavior.

Second, the rolling recruitment can improve the ecological validity of our RG tool set evaluations. By replenishing and expanding our sample systematically, we are able to capture a broader range of player behaviours, and responses to RG tools. Moreover, it also ensures the randomiser at the POC level can make as many diverse RG tool recommendations as possible, facilitating more comprehensive testing and evaluation of these tools for the recommendation system.

Third, the need for rolling recruitment is further underscored by the naturalistic setting of our study, which necessitates the ability to adapt to fluctuating risk levels, real-world behavioural changes, and industry-specific challenges such as player churn. Although we adjusted our initial sample size to account for expected attrition, the operators have provided statistics on the average monthly churn rate, which suggests a cumulative impact on the sample over time. As a result, we project the final sample size for the full 9-month POC phase to reach approximately X.

Finally, the player tagging system on entry adds a layer of methodological rigor to our study. By tagging new players upon entry, we are able to maintain the integrity of the initial sample. This means we are able to analyse attrition rates separately for the initial and rolling samples, thereby providing valuable insights into whether the study design or other factors are affecting engagement. Most importantly, the tagged groups ensure that the statistical power of the study remains robust. By knowing which cohort each player belongs to, we can apply more precise statistical models that account for potential confounders, thereby strengthening the validity and reliability of our findings. This is particularly crucial for the BETA stages, where understanding nuanced player behaviour will be essential for the machine learning models' training and validation.

Connection to Previous Amendments:

- **Data Collection (Amendment 1):** The extension of the data collection period such that the RG framework will be live for 9 months, inclusive of the POC and the BETA, The rolling recruitment strategy becomes necessary to ensure the data volume required for the BETA baseline dataset.
- **Participant Inclusion Threshold (Amendment 2):** The adjusted requirement for 20 Active Gambling Days (20AGD) serves as the benchmark for not only initial recruitment but also for the continuous enrollment of participants throughout the POC phase.

- **Consent Procedures (Amendment 3):** Any new players who join during the POC will be notified as per the amended notification procedures, ensuring the onboarding of new recruits is aligned to data privacy and regulator requirements.

A Safe Bet Project: Copy Amendments

This document outlines the key message revisions required for the A Safe Bet project in response to the October 2024 Netherlands Gaming Authority (KSA) regulatory requirements. The changes affect three primary communications: the enrollment message, monthly refresh message, and project page content. Each revision reflects the transition from a dynamic tool adjustment framework to an observational research approach.

1. Enrollment Message Revision

Content Changes

The original enrollment message focused on introducing new features and tool adjustments, suggesting active changes to players' responsible gambling experience. The revised version reframes this as a research participation announcement, emphasizing observation rather than intervention. Key differences include removing references to monthly adjustments and personalized tools while maintaining transparency about data usage.

Revise Copy

Welcome back!

Exciting news! Holland Casino has teamed up with Erasmus University Rotterdam and the University of Amsterdam for the *A Safe Bet* research project - and your account has been selected to take part!

Together, we're working to make gambling safer and more enjoyable for everyone by improving our responsible gambling tools. To do this, we'll look at how players like you use our existing safety features and find ways to make them even better.

What changes for you..? Nothing at all! Keep playing just like you always do. From time to time, we might ask about your experience with these tools.

By playing on our site, you're part of this project under our current Privacy Terms and Conditions. This means we'll share some of your play data with the research team to help improve responsible gaming tools. Your identity will stay anonymous to the research team.

For more information on our data policy and responsible play research, please visit our [T&Cs here] or the [Safe Bet Project page here]. If you have any questions, our [Support Team] is here to help.

2. Monthly Refresh Message Revision

Content Changes

The original refresh message announced monthly updates to RG settings and tool adjustments. The revised version transforms this into a general monthly check-in, encouraging players to review their existing tools without suggesting any changes. The tone shifts from announcing modifications to encouraging proactive engagement with current features.

Revised Copy

Hi [NAME]!

New month, fresh start! A perfect time to look at your playing and make a plan.

Our responsible gambling tools are here to help you enjoy playing safely. Whether it's checking your limits or setting new goals - small changes can make a big difference to your playing experience.

Want to set yourself up for success this month? Review your settings now [here – player account settings] - it only takes a minute.

Need help? Our friendly [Support Team] is always here to assist.

Here's to a great month of safe play!

3. Project Page Revision

Content Changes

The original project page detailed a complex system of dynamic tool adjustments and personalization. The revised version maintains the project's research focus while clarifying that current tools remain unchanged. It emphasizes the observational nature of the research and the value of player feedback in understanding tool effectiveness.

Revised Copy

A Safe Bet Project Page

[Operator Site] is always working to improve its Responsible Gaming (RG) features. That's why we've partnered with experts from Erasmus University Rotterdam and the University of Amsterdam on a project called *A Safe Bet*. Our goal is to use new research to make gaming safer, sustainable, and more enjoyable for everyone.

Why 'A Safe Bet' matters

As more people play online, we need better tools to ensure gambling is safe and enjoyable. We know that many players 'set and forget' their RG tools and current safety features often take a one-size-fits-all approach. Yet every player is unique, with different needs and playing styles.

That's why we aim to prevent problems before they start by creating tools that adapt to individual players. The purpose of *A Safe Bet* is to go beyond just setting limits - using the latest scientific research and data-driven insights, we're working to develop personalized tools that better support your playing experience.

What 'A Safe Bet' means for you – improve – like this should be now

Our goal is to make RG tools work better for you and feel more natural to use. You already have access to all the RG tools required by the KSA (Dutch Gambling Authority) and under Holland Casino's RG policy, including deposit limits and time limits. For now, these tools will stay exactly the same and continue to help keep your playing safe and enjoyable.

As part of *A Safe Bet*, we want to understand how players use these tools. You don't need to change anything about how you play - continue as normal. From time to time, we'll ask for your feedback to learn what works best for you. Your input will help us improve these tools and make them more useful for everyone.

When we develop new features or make changes to existing tools, we'll keep you informed every step of the way. Together, we can make RG tools better and easier to use.

From start to finish

A Safe Bet is a long-term project and journey we are on together. Right now, we're in the first phase - learning how players use our current tools and what they think about them. Your experience and feedback are essential for this research.

In the next phase, we'll use what we've learned to create new and better features. This careful approach helps us make sure any changes really work for our players.

Your data and privacy

We keep your personal information safe and private, and your identity remains anonymous to the research team. We strictly follow privacy regulations, ensuring your rights are always respected.

Questions? Want to learn more?

If you're curious about the *A Safe Bet* project or want more information, please contact our

customer service team. They're here to help and can direct any inquiries to our team.

The project page revisions maintain key sections (Why It Matters, What It Means for You, etc.) while adjusting content to reflect the observational research approach and existing KSA-mandated tools.

Amendment to 'A Safe Bet' Ethics Application ETH2122-0810

CONTEXT AND RATIONALE

This amendment addresses necessary changes to the Netherlands site (Holland Casino) of the A Safe Bet project in response to the October 2024 Netherlands Gaming Authority (KSA) regulatory requirements.

As of October 1st 2024, the KSA introduced new regulatory requirements for online gambling operators, fundamentally altering the landscape for responsible gambling research. These measures mandate standardized Responsible Gambling (RG) tools across all players, creating significant challenges for the original design of the *A Safe Bet* Proof of Concept (POC). This amendment addresses necessary changes to the implementation of the POC study of the *A Safe Bet* project in response to these requirements.

The KSA regulations prioritize compliance and uniformity through mandatory player protection measures. This standardized approach directly conflicts with the original *A Safe Bet* POC design, which focused on:

- Tailored RG tools based on player risk levels
- Randomized deployment of RG tools
- Monthly dynamic adjustment of RG tools

Despite extensive efforts to preserve the original POC framework within these new regulatory constraints, several critical challenges emerged:

1. Technical Implementation Barriers

- Regulatory compliance updates for Holland Casino demanded full development capacity from technical services
- No remaining capacity for re-development & implementation POC RG tools/interventions
- High risk of system instability if POC framework was layered over mandatory tools
- Potential for operational failures in critical player protection systems

2. Regulatory Compliance Risks

- Fundamental incompatibility between tailoring of RG tools and standardized regulatory mandates
- Legal uncertainty surrounding the implementation of research tools alongside mandatory tools
- Unacceptable risk of regulatory violations
- Potential compromise of operator licensing requirements

3. Participant Experience Concerns

- Risk of overwhelming participants with dual intervention systems
- High likelihood of player confusion between research and regulatory tools

- Potential for participant frustration leading to disengagement
- Compromise of both participant protection and study integrity
- Risk of reduced effectiveness of mandatory protective measures

PROPOSED SOLUTION & SCIENTIFIC FRAMEWORK

This amendment proposes a transition of the original POC version of the RG framework for Netherlands to a "Dummy" POC model, establishing a critical foundation for the *A Safe Bet* project's long-term research objectives. This adaptation preserves both research integrity and participant protection while serving three primary functions:

1. **Baseline Data Foundation:** The POC's primary role is establishing comprehensive baseline data, fundamental to the project's scientific validity. This serves to:
 - Provide the control period necessary for the Beta phase's Interrupted Time-Series design
 - Create a standardized reference point for understanding player behavior under regulatory tools
 - Ensure scientific rigor through clear pre-intervention behavioral patterns
 - Maintain compatibility with other jurisdictions' datasets while adhering to local requirements
2. **Research Continuity and Participant Engagement:** The framework focuses on building and maintaining a consistent participant base, crucial for research validity and future development. This approach:
 - Ensures cohort continuity across study phases, enabling reliable longitudinal analysis
 - Familiarizes participants with research processes, reducing future attrition
 - Provides continuous behavioral data for long-term pattern analysis
 - Creates the foundation for testing future adaptive interventions
 - Maintains scientific connection between baseline observations and future studies
3. **Research Scope Definition:** To maintain scientific integrity, the Dummy POC explicitly excludes:
 - Evaluation of regulatory tool effectiveness or harm prevention
 - Analysis of player engagement patterns with mandatory tools
 - Assessment of RG framework feasibility or implementation success
 - Comparison of behavioral outcomes across player groups
 - Any analysis of the Dutch regulatory system's impact

This framework ensures the Dummy POC serves as more than a regulatory compliance measure - it provides the scientific foundation necessary for meaningful research progression in the Netherlands market.

OVERVIEW OF PROPOSED AMENDMENTS

1. STUDY FRAMEWORK MODIFICATIONS

- Transition from dynamic RG tools to standardized KSA mandatory tools (€300/€700 deposit limits)
- Single standardized implementation for all participants
- Retention of scheduled breaks feature only

2. COMMUNICATION PROTOCOL REVISIONS

- Enhanced mandatory warning messages
- Updated player information resources
- Standardized monthly communications

3. METHODOLOGICAL ADJUSTMENTS

- Shift from evaluating adaptive RG tools to baseline data collection
- Daily BetBuddy monitoring for player behavior and risk assessment
- Tracking of player engagement with mandatory tools
- Continued qualitative research (interviews and surveys) with focus on standardized tools
- Maintained sample size (12,900) and study period (Feb-July 2025)
- Unchanged inclusion criteria and enrollment procedures

DETAILED AMENDMENT SPECIFICATIONS

1. STUDY FRAMEWORK SPECIFICATIONS

The regulatory changes introduced by the KSA necessitate a complete redesign of the study framework for the Netherlands site. The original POC utilized dynamic monthly deployment of tailored RG tools based on player risk levels. The revised framework implements standardized requirements through the following specifications:

1.1 Implementation of Mandatory Regulatory Tools

- 1.1.1 All participants will receive only the mandatory RG tools as specified in KSA regulations (reference: [Responsible Gaming Policy Rule 2024](#))
- 1.1.2 All A Safe Bet POC add-on RG tools have been deactivated - Mandatory tools include enforced net deposit limits: €300 per month (young adults under 25) and €700 per month (general players)
- 1.1.3 All limits operate on a calendar month basis with automatic deposit blocking - Changes require affordability checks and customer service approval. Net deposit calculations operate in real-time, subtracting withdrawals from deposits
- 1.1.4 Mandatory login and playtime controls enforce automatic logouts at maximum playtime and standardized cool-off periods
- 1.1.5 Players receive mandatory warning messages at both 50% and 100% of their limits, with risk warnings and limit adjustment instructions

- 1.2 Standardization Protocol:** The original POC design involved dynamic deployment and configuration of RG tools based on player risk levels. Under the revised framework, this variable approach is removed entirely. There is no randomization, risk-based selection, or dynamic configuration during the study period. Instead, mandatory tools are implemented with identical settings across all participants, ensuring regulatory compliance while maintaining system stability and consistent player experience.
- 1.3 Retention of Supplementary Feature:** The scheduled breaks feature remains as the only non-regulatory tool, providing players the option to set pre-defined gambling break periods. This feature, already part of Holland Casino's RG policy, offers a low-friction addition that complements the mandatory framework without adding complexity.

2. COMMUNICATION PROTOCOL SPECIFICATIONS

The participant communication framework has been revised to align with KSA regulatory requirements while maintaining the core POC communication principles. The standardized protocol encompasses three key components:

- 2.1 Enhancement of Regulatory Messaging:** KSA regulations mandate specific notifications for RG tool interactions (including fixed warnings at 50% and 100% of limit thresholds). These mandatory messages are enhanced with clear, engaging language that emphasizes protection and empowerment. Unlike the original POC's risk-based approach, these communications are standardized across all participants.
- 2.2 Information Resource Updates:** Two key player resources remain operational with revised content:
- 2.2.1** The "Player Limits Explained" page focuses on mandatory RG tools, providing clear explanations of deposit limits, logout mechanisms, and tool functionality through an accessible format
 - 2.2.2** The "A Safe Bet Project Page" continues to serve as the central information hub, focusing on the project's scope of measuring player engagement with RG tools and communication framework, while maintaining our commitment to transparent data handling and participant protection

2.3 Monthly Engagement Protocol: Despite removing risk-based tool deployment, we maintain regular participant engagement through the intended monthly refresh messages. These standardized communications will be updated to focus on awareness of mandatory RG tools, highlight their protective benefits, and reinforce participants' valuable role in the study. While no longer tailored, these messages maintain our project's supportive tone and commitment to participant engagement.

3. RESEARCH METHODOLOGY SPECIFICATIONS

The Dummy POC shifts from evaluating adaptive RG tools to establishing a comprehensive baseline dataset of player behavior under standardized regulatory measures (i.e., "the

status quo”). This revised framework maintains the original mixed-methods research approach while adapting its purpose.

- 3.1 **Quantitative Data Collection:** The BetBuddy algorithm continues daily player monitoring, now focused on establishing baseline behavioral patterns rather than informing intervention deployment. Data collection encompasses daily gambling metrics, risk level transitions, and tool interactions under the mandatory regulatory framework. These measurements are aggregated monthly to provide longitudinal behavioral insights and risk assessments. These metrics establish the baseline dataset essential for comparative analysis in the project’s future Alpha and Beta phases.
- 3.2 **Engagement Monitoring Protocol:** Comprehensive tracking of player interactions with mandatory RG tools continues, including response rates to notifications, tool usage patterns, and limit adjustment requests. This systematic monitoring provides insights into player engagement with standardized protective measures, informing future project phases while maintaining regulatory compliance.
- 3.3 **Qualitative Assessment:** The participant interview schedule continues, now examining experiences with standardized RG tools rather than the original adaptive framework. User satisfaction surveys maintain their original format and deployment schedule, with revised focus on interactions with mandatory tools.
- 3.4 **Sample Specifications:** The study maintains its original target sample size of 12,900 players and six-month duration period (February - July 2025) to ensure comparable data collection.
- 3.5 **Inclusion Parameters:** Inclusion criteria, enrollment procedures, and consent strategy remain unchanged from the original ethics application. Participants must meet established activity thresholds for study qualification, with risk level categorization continuing through our established frequency-based scoring method.
- 3.6 **Enrollment Protocol:** Participants receive an updated version of the non-dismissible notification about the study and data collection with the EUR at enrollment. Consent remains embedded within operator privacy statements, with continued access to study information through dedicated website pages.

ETHICAL CONSIDERATIONS AND SAFEGUARDS

The implementation of the revised POC framework maintains fundamental ethical research principles while aligning with the Netherlands’ regulatory requirements, which are among the most comprehensive player protection measures globally. The following specifications detail how participant protection and engagement are preserved and enhanced:

- 1. **Enhanced Protection Through Regulatory Integration:** The transition to the Netherlands’ stringent regulatory framework provides participants with robust protection that meets or exceeds our original study safeguards. The mandatory

measures, including strict deposit limits and enforced affordability checks, offer more comprehensive controls than our planned tools. Rather than compromising participant protection, this streamlined implementation strengthens safeguards while eliminating potential confusion from overlapping systems.

2. **Communication Protocol Safeguards:** The revised communication framework enhances mandatory notifications with supportive language, ensuring participants receive clear, engaging information about their protection. Rather than maintaining separate risk-based communications, we integrate supportive content into required messages, creating a more cohesive and effective communication approach. This unified strategy prevents message fatigue while maintaining our commitment to transparent communication. Dedicated information resources ensure participants remain well-informed about their comprehensive protections.
3. **Participant Engagement Mechanisms:** Our commitment to participant-driven research remains unchanged through the continuation of qualitative research components. The maintenance of participant interviews and satisfaction surveys, now focused on standardized regulatory tools, ensures players continue as active contributors to research development. This sustained engagement provides valuable insights for future project phases while preserving research inclusivity and participant voice.
4. **Risk Mitigation Protocol:** The framework modifications recognize that participant protection is enhanced, not diminished, by the regulatory transition. Our adapted framework leverages the Netherlands' comprehensive regulatory measures while carefully avoiding any additional complexity or stress. By implementing clear, consistent protective measures and removing redundant interventions, we prevent potential disengagement while ensuring participants receive the highest standard of protection available in online gambling environments.

These specifications ensure the continued prioritization of participant wellbeing, demonstrating how the regulatory framework's stringent requirements complement and enhance our research integrity and participant protection standards.